High Concept Document - FLIPSIDE

Game Jam: Game Design 3A - AI-Assisted Game Jam **Theme:** Switch **Developer:** Gift Zowa
Student Number: ST10443108 **Date:** March 2026

Title

FLIPSIDE

Genre

2D Split-Screen Puzzle Platformer

Core Loop

The screen is split horizontally into two halves at all times. The top half shows ARC moving through a bright, clean geometric world. The bottom half shows ECHO navigating a dark, mirrored version of the same space. Both worlds are always visible - but only one character is under the player's control at any time.

Pressing Tab switches control between ARC and ECHO. Whoever is inactive freezes right where they are, and their half of the screen dims. The active half brightens - there is always a clear visual signal telling you who you are controlling.

Physical Switch objects are scattered through each level - levers, buttons, panels. When a character activates one, something changes in the other world: a platform appears, a hazard disappears, a locked gate opens. ARC and ECHO depend on each other. Neither can finish a level alone.

Both characters need to reach their own exit doors to clear a level. When one gets to their exit, control moves to the other automatically. The order is not fixed - some levels want ARC to go first, some want ECHO, and some have you switching back and forth several times before either door opens.

Each character has their own countdown timer. The active character's timer drains at full speed. The inactive one drains at 25%. If either hits zero the level resets. Reaching both exits stops both timers and locks everything in place.

Core Loop:

1. Take in both worlds from the split screen before you move

2. Control the active character - navigate, jump, find Switches
3. Hit a Switch - watch the other world react in real time
4. Press Tab to hand control to the other character
5. Move through the changed world - progress or trigger the next Switch
6. Get both characters to their exits before either timer runs out

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Theme Interpretation

"Switch" works on three levels in this game simultaneously:

- **The action:** pressing a physical Switch in the level changes the world
- **The control:** pressing Tab switches which character you are running
- **The identity:** each world is a switched version of the other - light flipped to dark

The mechanic and the theme are the same thing here. Every meaningful action the player takes is an act of switching.

Visual Style

Two worlds that contrast strongly but clearly belong together:

ARC's World (Top - Light): White and pale grey geometric pixel art tiles. Sharp clean edges. A subtle cool blue tint. Clinical and calm. When active the half is fully lit. When inactive it drops to a deep shadow with a slow fade.

ECHO's World (Bottom - Dark): Deep black and dark charcoal geometric tiles. Thin neon purple glowing edges. Moody and mirror-like. Same brightness behaviour, same fade speed as ARC.

A cracked mirror line runs across the centre of the screen the whole time. When Tab is pressed, this line triple-flickers - white, then icy blue, then soft yellow - and fades out. It acts as a visual full stop on the switching mechanic.

Switch objects glow in their world's accent colour. SwitchableObjects appear semi-transparent when inactive so the player can always see what is there, just not use it yet.

Timers sit in the corner of each world half. The active timer goes from white to orange at 10 seconds, then red and strobing at 5. The inactive timer breathes slowly in icy blue with a frost icon and a gentle wave animation through the number characters.

Boost Orbs float and bob in the levels. Collecting one gives the other character a boost - speed, jump, or both. A glowing outline pulses around the boosted character for the duration.

All art was generated with Leonardo AI at 512x512, flat pixel art style, imported at matching PPU.

Intended Player Experience

The feeling I was going for is something like conducting two performers at the same time - always watching both sides, always thinking a step ahead. The key moment I wanted players to hit: "If I trigger that Switch as ARC right now, ECHO gets the path she needs - I can Tab over and use it immediately."

Difficulty scales through puzzle complexity, not platforming difficulty. Early levels walk the player through the basics gently. Later levels chain switches together, force multiple swaps back and forth, and pile on timer pressure across both characters at once.

The tone is calm, abstract, slightly mysterious. No dialogue or story text - everything communicates through level layout and the contrast between the two worlds.

Scope (Completed - 3-Day Jam)

- 7 handcrafted levels with increasing complexity (Level 8 stretch goal cut for time)
- Core mechanic: Tab to switch + physical Switch objects + SwitchableObjects
- Dual countdown timer system with active/inactive speed split
- Boost Orb system - collected by one character, benefits the other
- Moving hazards with ghost trail effect
- Split-screen always visible (two cameras, viewport rects)
- Inactive character freezes; camera dims on switch with asymmetric transition speed
- Animated UI: timer wave effects, frost icons, death flash with camera shake, label punch
- Title screen with letter-fade, float animation, and button slide-in
- Level complete screen with bounce slide-in and elastic header pop
- Exit door activation pulse and scale punch
- Hazard flash on death contact
- Predictive camera look-ahead on both cameras